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English 91

I arrived home in the winter wearing bright rainbow swimming trunks and my Stanford hoodie. I had run out of clean laundry, and rather than run a new load before my flight, I lugged a bag of dirty clothes back home for my dad to take care of over the break. I despised heaving my clothes up and down three flights of stairs in my dormitory to the washing machine, and I only now realized how spoiled I was by my father's laundry work. I indulged my indolence and hopped on the flight home.

When I walked through the creaky wooden front door, the one I'd opened a million times for a decade and a half, I was immediately greeted by a furry frenzy. Clementine rushed up to me, circling and jumping up with her paws outstretched. A light, innocent excitement was written on the Golden Retriever's face, and I shared her delight. Once she had calmed down, Calvin sturdily trodded up to me, panting loudly as he expectantly dug his head into my belly.

I love my dogs. I had been eagerly anticipating our reunion, and the enthusiasm reverberated through the house. But with that enthusiasm soon came a deep discomfort. I woke up the next morning with my nostrils full and a wheeze in my chest. I checked the clock and saw it was 10 AM: I had slept over ten hours. As I flitted my eyes open, I could hear the rhythmic patter of small footsteps getting closer and closer. Clementine strutted into the room, swaying side by side like a coiled spring. In her systematic manner, she observed the foot of my bed, eyeing it for a few seconds before leaping up and walking on top of me. She leaned her nose into my face, sniffing rapidly yet routinely.

I had mixed feelings as she stood over me. I knew the physiological consequences of such proximity. To start the day with coughs and sneezes would be difficult. Conversely, this

creature that stood over me was filled with love. I felt a deep sense of obligation and reciprocity, and I did not want to turn away the attention of this being who recognized and acknowledged me.

Why was it so difficult? Now, every time Clementine came up to me and sat down expectantly, I needed to make a choice. I could show her the love she expected and delighted in, but showing her that love entailed a biological risk to my well-being.